



NEC NP40

A diminutive powerhouse

The smallest of the NEC trio, the NP40 is a DLP projector, sporting an excellent on-paper contrast ratio of 1500:1. What we immediately liked was the tiny footprint—the NP40 was by far the smallest projector we received this year. Build quality-wise, there are no complaints, and the NP40 feels sturdy. The dull grey finish won't win many hearts, yet the overall tones aren't displeasing.

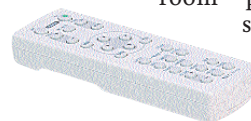
NEC has positioned the NP40 as a multimedia projector. We were therefore expecting DVI connectivity, but there was none. PC interfacing is via RS-232. The lack of USB or wireless connectivity won't impress the business audience. Audio inputs are absent too.

Setting up the NP40 is a snap mainly because there's hardly anything you can do wrong with the limited connectivity. The lens auto-focuses via an ultra-sharp and ultra-convenient optical zoom—nifty! Adjust the image size, and the lens will auto-focus; in fact, there is no manual focus control.



Our initial colour calibrations showcased the NP40's brilliant black level. The Pluge patterns in DisplayMate were clearly visible. Many projectors have a problem displaying very dark shades of grey, and black on a black background—not so with this projector!

Our sharpness and resolution tests gave the NP40 no problems whatsoever, and it exceeded the Acer PD726W here. The colour and greyscale tests were a breeze for the NP40, except for the colour purity of red: the NP40 seemed to display a shade of red that wasn't too far off from orange! Once we fiddled with the red balance a bit, the rendition of red seemed better, but it wasn't nearly as good as the performance of the Acer PD726W and the Sharp XG-C330X.



Moving on to our text and presentation tests: the NEC NP40 dominates big time here. It aced even the Acer PD726W (pun intended) and text quality was excellent, absolutely no anomalies noticeable. Our slideshow looked excellent, and any boardroom presentation will spring to life with the rich colours on display.

Movie watchers can shut their eyes and opt for the NEC NP40. It makes for an excellent home entertainment companion.

Our gaming tests did well on the NP40 too, especially the visual effects in *F.E.A.R.*, which were clear, sharp and precise—absolutely no loss of detail or pixelation even through fast action scenes.

With sterling scores throughout our tests, the NP40 slides into second position, just losing out to the feature-rich Acer PD726W and bagging the Digit Best Buy Silver Award. At Rs 1,00,800, we recommend this projector for anyone, business or home user alike, who wants uncompromised visual quality; its small footprint also makes it sufficiently portable.

Panasonic PT-LB60EA

For the presenter in you!

Panasonic's PT-LB60 is a big unit sporting a low profile and a classy looking silver-grey finish that'll assure second glances. Everything from the lens cover to the buttons on its surface breathe supreme build quality. We liked the rear-mounted buttons, namely the menu button and the five-way joystick—reminiscent of a cell phone. Menu navigation is very comfortable even without the remote unit. The menu structure is good, though NEC does their menu layout just a touch better.

The PT-LB60 offers a multitude of connectivity options—there are two D-Sub ins, the second of which functions as an out too. PC and RCA audio outputs are also present. Wireless connectivity is possible, though the USB interface has been left out. Overall, the

PT-LB60's connectivity should satisfy most corporate users.

DisplayMate's first set of tests favoured the PT-LB60, and this projector didn't have any issues with resolution or sharpness.

It performed well in the colour tests as well, with great rendition of all primary and secondary colours. However, in the greyscale portion of the tests, the PT-LB60 has issues in the black shift test, and the shades of the black bars weren't uniform as they should ideally be. There were also slight issues with flickering, which was more noticeable on this projector than on the other XGA projectors.

Business users will enjoy vibrant presentations and clear, crisp text. Both the photograph and movie quality tests were also passed very well indeed.



The Panasonic PT-LB60 makes for a decent gaming companion. Although the lack of contrast is noticeable especially in dark atmospheric games like *F.E.A.R.*, performance was acceptable overall.

At Rs 1,64,990, the PT-LB60 is feature-rich, albeit pricey and makes a good business projector. It performed commendably in all the business tests, with no serious complaints. Multimedia users will also be happy with the performance on offer, but there are better options available in the home entertainment segment.